leftism has a premium … As far as BJP is concerned, economically and socially, we are not a revolutionary party. We are not a traditional party as such. There is modernity in our approach but that doesn't make us a right-wing party.'[46]

If the BJP is not right-wing economically, then what does it stand for? A political party's economic philosophy cannot, 'unlike Jack's beanstalk, grow into a giant tree overnight nor can it, like Macduff, "be ripped untimely" from its mother's womb'.[47] In that sense, it is instructive to look at how its economic ideas evolved over time, and how some of its foundational ideas continue to have an afterlife.

The Jan Sangh Phase: When Karl Marx Was as 'Out of Date' as Adam Smith

Much like demonetisation, the pedigree of some other key economic initiatives of the BJP government can be traced back to the foundations of the party. In 2018, for example, Modi appealed to Indians to buy Indian products.[48] It was an easy step from there to the all-encompassing idea of 'AatmaNirbhar Bharat' (Self-Reliant India), which became Modi's signature economic slogan in 2020 after the national lockdown. The intellectual roots of this strain of swadeshi thinking in the BJP go back to the Jan Sangh. As Vajpayee argued in 1971, as party president, 'Let us use only what is produced in this country. This will release Indian initiative for invention and enterprise. The Swadeshi cult was so successful before independence. Why should it not be successful now?… You have got to enthuse them. Today people are getting crazy over imported things and even pay fabulous prices for them. If the cult of Swadeshi is not revived, the slogan for import substitution would be hollow … what we need today is realism. It is no use borrowing ideas from textbooks on socialism and communism. We have been hearing of socialism for decades but how much of it are we having this country today? The majority of the people in this country today live in abject poverty … and we have to take a pragmatic approach to solve the problems.'[49]